

Introduction

Before enrolling in this module, possibly due to the marginalisation of media education in compulsory education or the narrow definition of literacy in textbooks, I held several misconceptions about media literacy. Firstly, I erroneously believed that acquiring media literacy necessitated prior mastery of "real literacy" (i.e., traditional printed literacy) and the technical skills needed for its practice (Cannon, Potter, and Burn, 2018). However, it's crucial to understand that literacy goes beyond being a mere form of knowledge capital that automatically grants power once skills are obtained. It should be regarded as a condition highly sensitive to changes in context (Cannon and Potter, 2019). When this condition is met, individuals can participate in society to their fullest extent (Poyntz et al., 2020). Another misunderstanding was that I comprehend the superficial complexity of modern "digital capitalism" (Buckingham, 2019) without actively recognising the role that ownership, pluralism, and competition play in shaping media in the digital age (Poyntz et al., 2020).

Potter and McDougall (2017) provide insight into the evolving dynamics of meaning-making and communication, as suggested by Lievrouw and Livingstone (2006), with the term "dynamic." In my comprehension, this term indeed carries significant guiding implications. Dynamic literacy is not a residual category of literacy but rather encompasses and broadens the overall vision of literacy (Cannon, Potter, and Burn, 2018). Consequently, media education should adapt harmoniously to the continually changing reality, staying attuned to learners' contexts involving broader historical and ideological issues (Masterman, 1989). On a practical level, it should equip students with competencies in media literacy, enabling them to decipher media texts and institutions, engage in media production practices, and cultivate a

culturally sensitive perspective on literacy in their daily lives (Poyntz et al., 2020; Street, 2003).

This article will critically examine the production process of a 3-minute short film themed around "fortune," incorporating relevant literature in film and media studies. As one of the creators, actively participating in production tasks like storyboarding, filming, editing, and reflection—integral elements of media literacy practices—allows me to surpass conventional critical analysis exercises (Poyntz et al., 2020). This involvement enables the contemplation of media consumption's personal and emotional dimensions, fostering a more comprehensive and crucial exploration of media.

Filmmaking

1 Main Theme

Upon receiving the theme of "fortune," our group initially reached a consensus to utilize this assignment as an opportunity to demonstrate our understanding of fortune and our understanding of utopia. We aim to reveal what we consider fortunate and valuable, thereby illustrating our values, which include one aspect of our identity. In other words, we employ available media means—specifically, a film constructed from moving-image editing—to curate our identity (McDougall and Potter, 2018). Unlike printed literacy, film's fluid and adaptable nature enables seamless integration with distinctive social contexts. The affordances of film, as a mode of media, allow us to articulate to some extent the circumstances of our lives as creators.

Inspired by Huston's (1973, p. 60) insight into filmmaking and editing, "Film is like thought. It's the closest to the thought process of any art," our primary focus is to design a cinematic experience that mirrors a natural thought process, deeming it the most effective means to afford our intended theme. Initially, we deliberated that adhering to a concrete and figurative storyline would impede our ability to maximise the advantages of dynamic images in expressing ideas (BFI, 2000). Adopting an abstract concept to present without mature filming and editing skills was overly idealistic and risked confusing spectators. Hence, I suggested structuring the content within a narrative framework to better convey the film's intended meaning (Poyntz et al., 2020).

During our discussions, I uncovered a shared admiration for the painter Van Gogh with another teammate. His ability to appreciate and document beauty in hard times particularly impressed both of us. Subsequently, we refined the idea of using the protagonist's trip to view Van Gogh's sunflowers at the National Gallery as a thematic thread. Throughout the filmmaking process, our team embodied the "inspirative" qualities described by one participant in Cannon and Potter's (2019) study of "The Clip Club." Parallel to this participant, our team members' actions and ideas were stewarded inclusively during the practice, ensuring individuals had enhanced agency through creative participation (Burn and Durran, 2007).

2 Storyboard and Proposal

The storyboard and proposal were collaboratively created, allocating particular tasks based on individual strengths and capacities. The entire process involved substantial mutual inspiration and coordination. Unlike a shooting script, which primarily focuses on addressing practical concerns, storyboards excel at coordinating visual effects with the creators' intentions (BFI,

2000). Moreover, as a practical tool of media literacy, the storyboard proves especially effective in transforming abstract prose passages into film (BFI, 2013). The extensive 24-page storyboard reflects our awareness that most media-literate work necessitates meticulous attention to the language of the moving image, with every detail carefully arranged (Reid, Burn, and Parker, 2002). In the comprehensive planning process, we concurrently simulated scenarios on the shooting day and anticipated the audience's experience. My familiarity with the primary shooting location, the National Gallery, also appears to contribute. On the other hand, as the plot required filming during weekday peak times in public spaces, we simultaneously prepared ourselves for improvisational changes and decisions based on on-site conditions.

In the planning phase, when exploring ways to portray flashbacks, the term "montage" immediately crossed my mind, bringing both surprise and enthusiasm. With a deep passion for films since high school and experience working in the film industry for the past three summers, I still consider myself a film enthusiast without practical experience. From a module design standpoint, Cannon and Potter (2019) propose storyboarding as a pedagogical strategy and an illustration of dynamic literacy. It allows students to re-evaluate and express their accumulated knowledge of the moving image. From a learner's viewpoint, storyboarding serves as a literacy practice, allowing students to tentatively apply implicit film knowledge to the production realm based on their existing understanding. Given the group's careful approach to presenting a crucial scene, persuading teammates to adopt my idea required providing more substantial justifications. Therefore, I delved deeper into the advantages, disadvantages, and specific cases of montage as a filming technique. Our collaboration did not necessarily involve compromising by any individual; instead, it aimed to convey the creators' ideas to the broadest audience in the most developed way (Murch, 2001). Regarding my rewards, I discovered that group collaboration effectively facilitates learners' acquisition

of additional skills and methods (Jenkins, 2009). These benefits became more apparent during the editing stage.

3 Shooting and Editing

Thanks to careful planning, our shooting process proved highly efficient. However, considering the dynamism that media projects should exhibit, we adhered to the principles of trying things out, making autonomous decisions, and being open to uncertainty, as Cannon, Potter, and Burn (2018) advocated. Shooting in public spaces like the tube, Trafalgar Square, and gallery necessitated continual adjustments and deliberate trade-offs. For instance, the recognisable entrance was relocated due to renovations, which led us to abandon a fixed low-angle panoramic shot. Instead, we opted for a mobile shot following the actor's movement, ultimately focusing on the National Gallery sign. Surprisingly, during editing, we discovered that the natural camera shakes during this movement better aligned with the emotional tone and enriched the shot.

An illustrative example was the relocation of the National Gallery's entrance during renovations, prompting the abandonment of a fixed low-angle panoramic shot in favour of a mobile shot tracking the actor's movements, culminating in a focused shot on the National Gallery sign. The subsequent editing phase unveiled a pleasant surprise: the natural camera shakes during movement significantly complemented the emotional tone, enriching the shot. Our team received bonuses for creatively solving problems, with team members consistently making spontaneous and creative attempts. To prevent rework, we imagined potential editing at the venue and adjusted for reshooting if needed. While capturing a sequence of emotional shots, my real-time recorded feelings as an actor became pivotal cues for selecting the appropriate soundtrack during the editing stages. These situational practices, drawn from

daily life, were creatively employed to elevate performance in production practice (Banaji, Burn, and Buckingham, 2006).

Creativity extends into the editing phase, where team members consistently enhance each other's sense of 'rightness' during the process, fostering a reflexively literate state (Cannon, Potter, and Burn, 2018). Described as "sticking the dismembered pieces together" (Murch, 2001, p. 57), editing breathes new soul into moving image materials, intending to evoke a dream-like, continuously shifting sensation for viewers. As Murch (2001, p. 58) expressed, "one realisation suddenly overwhelms everything else" during the film. Alongside emotionally suggestive background music, natural white noise is introduced to craft an immersive sensory environment (Poyntz et al., 2020). Empowered by iMovie as a tool with creative potential, the team engages in creative compositional production, positioning themselves as actors rather than editors confined by source material limitations (Hoechsmann and Poyntz, 2012, p. 109). In a point-of-view shot indicating the tumultuous search process, a yawning passer-by at the frame's centre raised concerns about unintentionally diverting audience attention. Consequently, we employed iMovie to incorporate a Dutch angle shot effect, further intensifying the tension and unease within this segment.

4 Screening and Reflection

We invited friends to preview our film in advance, recognising that creative works necessitate feedback through the presentation, catalysing further refinement (Poyntz et al., 2020). Some friends mentioned that the central theme was muddled. Following our explanation, the audience offered valuable and inspiring suggestions. For example, they proposed employing double or even triple exposure to create a match cut between the sunflowers in real life, the sunflowers in the painting, and the sunflowers mirrored in the protagonist's eyes. Their

insights, rooted in audience experience, go beyond our editing expertise as creators. This provoked our reconsideration of how to edit discontinuity to optimise the impact of each frame, making the film "as sharp and to the point as they are" (Murch, 2001, p. 8). According to Poyntz et al. (2020), this emphasises how the dynamic relationship between practice and imagination shapes the reflective process. In the final screening class, we found satisfaction as even classmates unfamiliar with the film accurately identified its theme. This production practice appears to prove that media literacy, as exemplified by film, has the potential to transform abstract expressions of identity into palpable modalities through collective cultural actions (Cannon, Potter, and Burn, 2018). However, I acknowledge that the selected audience has a thorough grasp of our creators' social and historical context, structure of feeling, and personal preferences due to a shared background of the last three years (Cannon, 2018). This familiarity probably affects how they interpret the message that our movie as a medium is trying to convey.

The comprehensive grade-wide screening allowed students to compare their interpretations of the literary source—precisely, the term "fortune" and its oral and written explication, respectively, in lectures and slides—with alternative moving image versions (BFI, 2000). This event served as an opportunity for teachers, acting as experts, to provide feedback. The unfolding of one specific incident triggered my reflection and enhanced my comprehension of the key terms. During group discussions on emphasising emotional changes through editing, diverse opinions emerged. The consensus was reached on using filters, a common method for ambience creation, to showcase our editing awareness to teachers and enable the audience to deduce our intentions through familiarity with typical film techniques. However, influenced by Murch's (2001) inquiry, we questioned whether these techniques originated in daily life or became habitual merely because filmmakers consistently used them (Murch, 2001).

Ultimately, we made the decision to adopt a more imaginative approach, incorporating music with a “sudden disruption of reality” to imply emotional shifts (Murch, 2001, p. 16). During the grade-wide screening, a teacher commended another team's use of filters to differentiate emotions. This suggestion prompted me to contemplate whether, within the university context and the authoritative teacher-student relationship (Poyntz et al., 2020), we would have had less exploratory discussion and experimentation if the teacher had explicitly communicated the preference for using filters before editing. The concept of the third space, commonly employed in exploring cross-cultural identity (Bhabha, 1994), appears suitable for further explanation. In the education context, once liberated from the constraints of a standard curriculum, the power dynamics between teachers and students become less defined and more flexible (Cannon and Potter, 2019). Students immerse themselves in production within the third space, facing challenges and exploring possibilities. Therefore, learning in the third space is imperative to activate learners' agency fully. The flexibility and adaptability of teacher-student power dynamics also play a significant role in why this assignment yielded substantial gains through spontaneous exploration.

Conclusion

The group expresses overall satisfaction with the assignment, seemingly unrelated to the final score. It is the production practices and impacts on mindset that rewarded us. My regret arises from the oversight in Poyntz et al.'s (2020) discussion of dynamic literacy, particularly the crucial role of a cyclic and iterative process. Here, the ongoing cycle should involve in-depth engagement with film theory, meticulous frame-by-frame analyses, practical application, feedback reception, subsequent adjustments, and the initiation of new cycles. Throughout the

three-month study, we were guided to complete this cycle as comprehensively as possible, but a single cycle proved less than ideal. In my view, cumulative cycles will lead to a more thorough and illuminating knowledge of both film and media literacy.

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